



▲ FRASER ISLAND

These dunes on the shore of Fraser Island, eastern Australia, are part of the longest sequence of coastal dunes in the world.

COASTAL DUNES

Sandy beaches that do not lie at the foot of cliffs are often backed by sand dunes. These are built up by wind blowing off the sea and rolling dry sand grains inland. The dune ridges keep moving downwind, as sand is blown up one side and down the other. But eventually, the dunes are stabilized by the roots of tough plants that can grow in the salty sand.



SPITS

Some long beaches extend into offshore spits. Sand and pebbles shifted along the beach by longshore drift are added to the tip of the spit, so it keeps on growing. Dungeness Spit on the Pacific coast of Washington State, seen here, grows by 15 ft (4.5 m) each year.

LONG BEACHES

Longshore drift can create beaches that extend for incredible distances along the coast. They often form banks with the sea on one side and sheltered lagoons on the other side. These long beaches absorb the force of breaking waves during storms, protecting the true shore from erosion.

► 90 MILE BEACH

Extending along a shore in the far north of New Zealand, this spectacular beach is actually 56 miles (90 km) long.

Sheltered lagoon forms between the beach and the land



WOW!

The longest natural beach lies on the coast of southern Bangladesh. Known as Cox's Bazar, it extends for 75 miles (120 km).